Pickup Measures

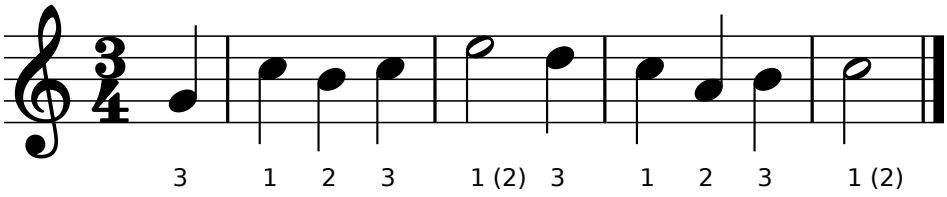
A **pickup**, also called an **anacrusis**, is one or more notes that come before the first full measure of a piece. The **pickup measure** is incomplete: it holds fewer beats than the time signature calls for.

When a piece begins with a pickup, the final measure is shortened by the same amount. The pickup measure and the final measure together equal one full measure.

Counting begins on the last beats of the pickup measure. In 3/4, a one-beat pickup is counted "3", and the first full measure begins on "1". In 4/4, a pickup of two eighth notes fills the second half of the measure and is counted "4 &".

Example 1: 3/4 with a one-beat pickup

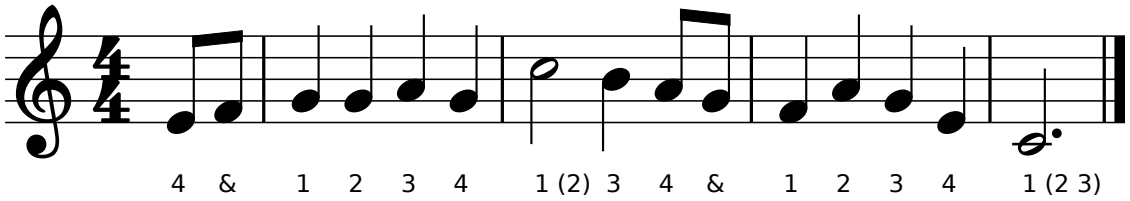
The pickup holds one beat. The final measure holds two beats. One plus two equals three, one full measure of 3/4.



Counts are written under the notes.

Example 2: 4/4 with a pickup of two eighth notes

The pickup holds one beat (two eighth notes). The final measure holds three beats, a dotted half note. One plus three equals four.



Counts are written under the notes.

Finding the pickup

To check a pickup, add up the beats in the first measure. If the total is less than the top number of the time signature, the measure is a pickup. Then count backward from the last beat of the measure to find where the pickup begins. In 4/4, a one-beat pickup is counted "4"; a two-beat pickup is counted "3 4"; a three-beat pickup is counted "2 3 4".

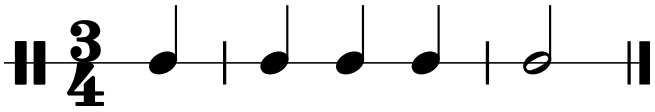
© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.

Name _____ Date _____

Pickup Measures

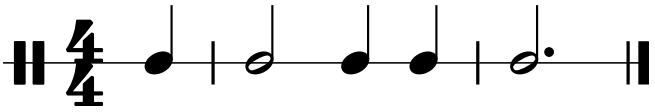
A. Pickup measures Write the number of beats in each pickup measure.

EXAMPLE



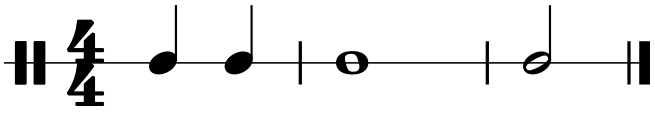
Beats in pickup: 1

1.



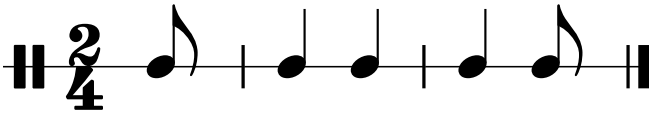
Beats in pickup: _____

2.



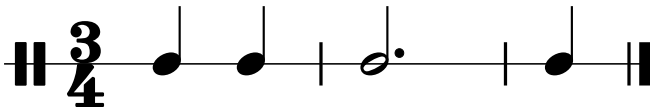
Beats in pickup: _____

3.



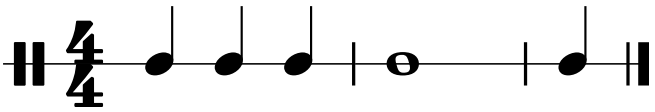
Beats in pickup: _____

4.



Beats in pickup: _____

5.



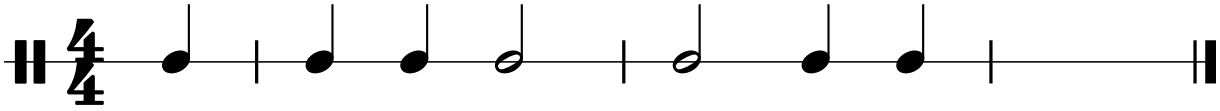
Beats in pickup: _____

B. Complete the final measure Write notes in the final measure so that it completes the pickup measure.

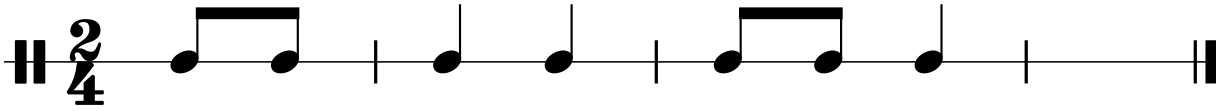
EXAMPLE



1.

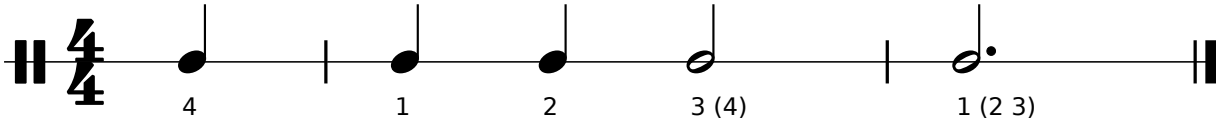


2.

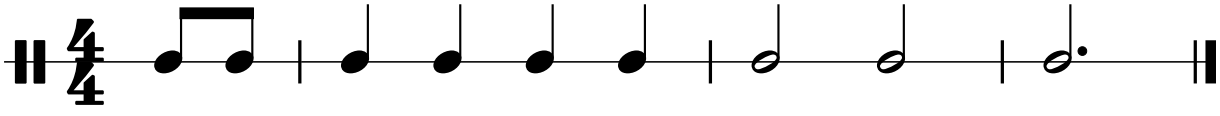


C. Counting pickups Write the counts under each rhythm. Begin the pickup on the count it falls on.

EXAMPLE



1.



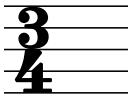
© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.

Name _____ Date _____

Review: Meter and Rhythm

A. Time signatures Complete each line.

EXAMPLE



Beats 3

Beat note quarter note

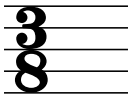
1.



Beats _____

Beat note _____

2.

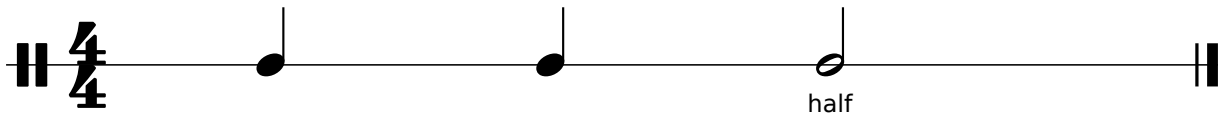


Beats _____

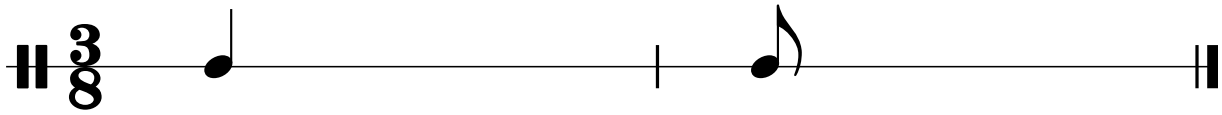
Beat note _____

B. Complete the measures Add one note to the end of each measure to complete it.

EXAMPLE

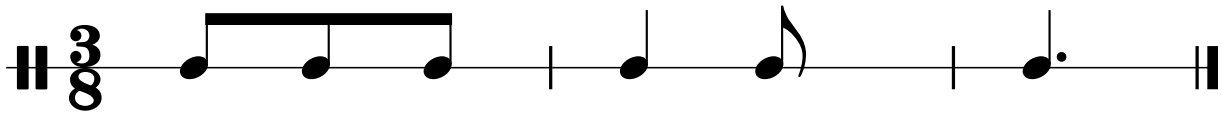


1.

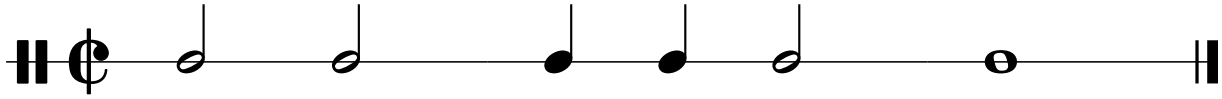


C. Add the bar lines Draw a bar line after each complete measure.

EXAMPLE



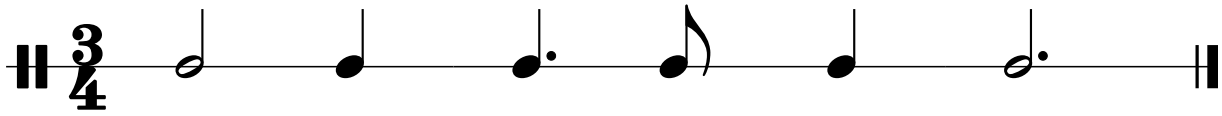
1.



2.

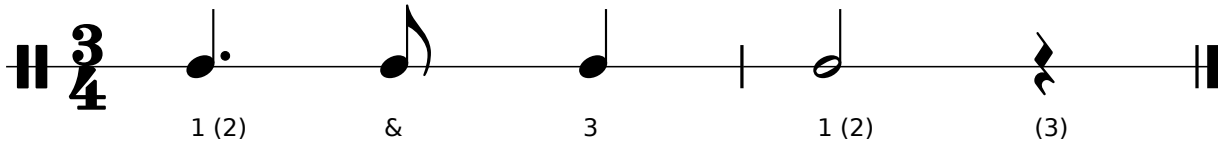


3.



D. Counting Write the counts under the rhythm. Put held and rested beats in parentheses.

EXAMPLE



1.



© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.